

The Quiet Machine

Chapter 1

In the back of the workshop stood a machine that no one had built and no one could explain. It hummed at a pitch just below hearing, and it asked for nothing and it gave back only exactly what you put into it.

The apprentices were afraid of it. The old engineer was not. Each evening he wiped it down with a soft cloth, the way you might dust a sleeping animal, and each morning he greeted it before he greeted anyone else.

Chapter 2

A young woman came to the workshop wanting the machine to make her clever. She fed it her cleverest book and turned the crank, and out came the very same book, unchanged, still unread.

You cannot take out what you have not put in, the old engineer said. The machine does not add. It only returns, faithfully, what you were willing to give it.

Chapter 3

Years later, when the engineer had gone, the woman ran the workshop herself. She kept the machine polished and quiet, and she taught the apprentices not to fear it, but to be honest with it.

For that, she told them, was its only secret: it answered honesty with honesty, effort with effort, patience with patience, and it never once pretended to be anything more than a faithful mirror with a gentle hum.